

Haiti

Occupying the western third of the island of Hispaniola, Haiti is one of the most mountainous countries in the Caribbean. It is also the poorest. About 95 per cent of its people are descendents of black slaves. The country is overcrowded, and has suffered deforestation, soil erosion, and desertification, as well as a turbulent political history.



Voodoo

A Haitian blend of West African religions and Christianity, voodoo uses drums, singing, and dance. Its followers believe that through worship of spirits, they can live in harmony with nature and their dead. Many celebrations coincide with Christmas and the Mexican Day of the Dead.

Voodooists on Gede, or All Saint's Day

HAITI FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Port-au-Prince
AREA	27,750 sq km (10,714 sq miles)
POPULATION	8,200,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	French, French Creole
MAJOR RELIGIONS	Christian, Voodoo
CURRENCY	Gourde



Port-au-Prince

Smart modern hotels have lured many visitors to Haiti's capital, Port-au-Prince. The city has two cathedrals, a university, and many government buildings. However, it also has the worst slums in the Caribbean, most of which are found to the north of the centre. They have no water facilities and are overcrowded.

Puerto Rico

About 1,600 km (994 miles) southeast of Miami, the crowded island of Puerto Rico is a self-governing territory of the USA. It is home to more than 3.8 million people, of African and Spanish descent, of whom half live in the capital, San Juan. An old walled city, it has colonial buildings.



Balconies, old San Juan

Dominican Republic

Lying 966 km (600 miles) southeast of Florida, the Dominican Republic spreads across the eastern two-thirds of Hispaniola. It has the Caribbean's highest peak, Pico Duarte, 3,175 m (10,417 ft), and also its lowest point, crocodile-infested Lake Enriquillo, 44 m (144 ft) below sea-level. Nickel, amber, and gold mining are important industries, and holidaymakers flock to the island for its long, pearly beaches, modern hotels, and wildlife.



People

With a higher standard of living than neighbouring Haiti, the Dominican Republic provides good healthcare for its people. The mixed race middle classes form about 73 per cent of the population. The minority of blacks work as farmers, selling their produce at market.



Tobacco leaves are hung upside down to dry and then made into cigars and cigarettes.

Farming

About 24 per cent of the labour force work on farms, which are mostly in the north and east of the country, and in the San Juan valley. Sugar, tobacco, and cocoa are main crops, and, although the market has slowed, most are exported to the USA.

DOMINICAN REPUBLIC FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Santo Domingo
AREA	48,730 sq km (18,815 sq miles)
POPULATION	8,500,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	Spanish, French Creole
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Dominican Republic peso



Tourism

The Dominican Republic is the largest tourist destination in the Caribbean, attracting two million each year. The industry brings in half of the country's earnings and provides much-needed jobs.

St Kitts and Nevis

The two islands of St Kitts (or St Christopher) and Nevis sit in the northern part of the Leeward Islands. Both are mountainous, and their idyllic, palm-fringed beaches attract many tourists. Most people are descendents of black Africans, and nearly all work in farming or tourism.



ST KITTS AND NEVIS FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Basseterre
AREA	360 sq km (139 sq miles)
POPULATION	41,000
MAIN LANGUAGE	English
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Eastern Caribbean dollar

Sugar-cane

The main crop on St Kitts is sugar-cane, which accounts for 25 per cent of exports and provides 12 per cent of jobs. Low world prices and hurricane damage have created problems.

Antigua and Barbuda

The largest of the Leeward Islands, Antigua has two dependencies: Barbuda, a small, coral island bursting with wildlife, and Redonda, an uninhabited rock with its own king. The blue lagoons and corals that surround Antigua teem with tropical fish.



ANTIGUA AND BARBUDA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	St John's
AREA	440 sq km (170 sq miles)
POPULATION	66,400
MAIN LANGUAGE	English
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Eastern Caribbean dollar

Yachting

The harbour at St John's has an annual Sailing Week that attracts many visitors and rich yachtspeople. Cruise ships and luxury boats call at the 18th-century Nelson's Dockyard.